

DREAMING AGES HISTORY · EPISODE 4

Ancient Greece

A Calm Journey Across the Aegean

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A BEDTIME COMPANION

Two maps, a timeline from the palaces of Crete to the coming of Rome, the people and places you'll meet in the episode, and a short list of trusted books, museums and podcasts, for the evenings when you would like to wander a little further.

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The Greek mainland and the Aegean

Greece was never one country. Hundreds of city-states grew up in mountain valleys and on islands and coasts, linked by the sea, sharing a language, gods and festivals.



Ancient sites plotted at their real locations on a modern base map (Natural Earth). Coastlines are modern; some, such as the bay at Troy and the pass at Thermopylae, have changed a great deal since antiquity.

Places you'll visit in the episode

Knossos: the great Minoan palace on Crete, with painted corridors and a central court.

Olympia: sanctuary of Zeus, home of the games, traditionally first held in 776 BCE.

Sparta: the city of the Spartiates, two kings, ephors and the agoge.

Marathon: the plain where Athenians and Plataeans defeated a Persian force in 490 BCE.

Epidaurus: sanctuary of Asclepius, the god of healing, with its great theatre.

Mycenae: the walled citadel of the Bronze Age Greeks, whose palaces fell around 1200 BCE.

Delphi: Apollo's sanctuary on the slopes of Mount Parnassus, seat of the oracle.

Athens: the city of Cleisthenes and Pericles, crowned by the Parthenon on its Acropolis.

Thermopylae · Salamis: the narrow pass and the sea battle of 480 BCE.

Pella: capital of Macedon, birthplace of Alexander.

TWO THOUSAND YEARS, SLOWLY

A timeline of the Greek world



Early dates are approximate; "ancient Greece" here runs from the Bronze Age to the Roman conquest.

c. 1900 BCE
The first Minoan palaces rise on Crete, Knossos among them.

c. 1600–1100 BCE
The Mycenaean age; Linear B records an early form of Greek.

c. 1200 BCE
The Bronze Age palaces collapse, for reasons still debated.

776 BCE
The first Olympic games, by tradition.

8th c. BCE
The alphabet is adapted from Phoenician; Homer's epics take shape.

594 BCE
Solon's reforms at Athens.

508/507 BCE
Cleisthenes' reforms lay the foundations of Athenian democracy.

499 BCE
The Ionian Revolt against Persia.

490 BCE
Marathon.

480 · 479 BCE
Thermopylae and Salamis; then Plataea and Mycale.

478 BCE
The Delian League is formed, later an Athenian empire.

447–432 BCE
The Parthenon is built.

431–404 BCE
The Peloponnesian War; plague strikes Athens in 430.

415–413 BCE
The Sicilian Expedition ends in disaster.

399 BCE
The trial and death of Socrates.

371 · 338 BCE
Thebes defeats Sparta at Leuctra; Philip II wins at Chaeronea.

336–323 BCE
Alexander's reign; he dies in Babylon.

Third century BCE
Alexandria's Library and Museum flourish; Euclid works there.

212 BCE
Archimedes dies at Syracuse.

146 BCE
Rome destroys Corinth; Greece passes under Roman rule.

From the Aegean to the Indus



Approximate extent of Alexander's empire at his death in 323 BCE, simplified from the open historical-basemaps dataset; borders are approximate. Long before, Greek colonies such as Massalia (Marseille), Syracuse and Byzantion had spread around the Mediterranean and the Black Sea.

People you'll meet

Homer: the poet, or tradition of poets, of the Iliad and the Odyssey.

Cleisthenes: reformer whose changes of 508/507 BCE began Athenian democracy.

Themistocles: Athenian who built the fleet that won at Salamis.

Herodotus: historian of the Persian Wars.

Socrates: philosopher of Athens, tried and put to death in 399 BCE.

Alexander the Great: king of Macedon from 336 BCE; died in Babylon in 323 BCE.

Solon: Athenian lawgiver of the early 500s BCE.

Leonidas: Spartan king who fell at Thermopylae in 480 BCE.

Pericles: leading Athenian of the mid-400s, behind the building of the Acropolis.

Sophocles: tragic poet of Athens, beside Aeschylus and Euripides.

Plato · Aristotle: Plato founded the Academy; his student Aristotle, the Lyceum.

Archimedes: mathematician and engineer of Syracuse; died in 212 BCE.

Legend or history?

Some famous stories sit between myth and history: the Trojan War, Homer as one single poet, and the "three hundred" at Thermopylae (thousands of other Greeks fought there too). The date 776 BCE for the first Olympics is a later tradition. The episode keeps these apart from what the sources and archaeology show.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Learn more





Artistic impressions of the court at Knossos and of the sanctuary of Delphi, made for the episode. They are not historical records.

Books

Introducing the Ancient Greeks ↗, Edith Hall (W. W. Norton, 2015).

Ancient Greece: A Very Short Introduction ↗, Paul Cartledge (Oxford University Press, 2011).

The Hemlock Cup: Socrates, Athens and the Search for the Good Life ↗, Bettany Hughes (Knopf, 2011).

The Histories ↗, Herodotus, trans. Tom Holland (Penguin Classics, 2015).

The Landmark Thucydides ↗, ed. Robert B. Strassler (Free Press, 1998).

The Odyssey ↗, Homer, trans. Robert Fagles (Penguin).

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Full reading list ↗

Museums & places

Acropolis Museum, Athens.

National Archaeological Museum, Athens: the finds from Mycenae.

British Museum, London: the Parthenon sculptures.

Royal Ontario Museum, Toronto: the Gallery of Greece.

Podcasts

The History of Ancient Greece, Ryan Stitt: a deep, narrative history from the Bronze Age onward.

"Tonight that conversation softens into hush. The oars are shipped. The harbour is still."

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Dreaming Ages History · Narration is AI-generated text-to-speech; illustrations are AI-generated artistic impressions. Facts follow the episode script and its sources. Maps drawn from real coordinates: Natural Earth; historical borders simplified from the open historical-basemaps dataset (A. Ourednik). Free for personal use. Sleep well. 🌙